

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 150

By McNally

A RESOLUTION to honor members of the 134th Air Refueling Wing of the Tennessee Air National Guard on receiving the Distinguished Flying Cross.

WHEREAS, our nation was conceived by individuals who were willing to sacrifice their personal safety and concerns to ensure our individual and collective freedom, and the Volunteer State is especially proud to be the home of so many valiant men and women who have performed above and beyond the call of duty; and

WHEREAS, while the heroic deeds of Tennesseans have been extolled throughout the history of our State and nation, the distinguished military service of every proud Tennessean should be illuminated, shared, and properly honored but perhaps none more so than the recent heroic actions of the members of the 134th Air Refueling Wing of the Tennessee Air National Guard, who have been awarded the Distinguished Flying Cross for their actions during an attack on Israel, April 13-14, 2024; and

WHEREAS, the Distinguished Flying Cross is awarded for heroism or extraordinary achievement while participating in aerial flight. The heroism or achievement must be entirely distinctive, involving operations that are not routine; the Distinguished Flying Cross is the highest award for extraordinary aerial achievement and has only been awarded to KC 135 crew members twenty-five times in our nation's history; and

WHEREAS, the Airmen of the 134th Air Refueling Wing of the Tennessee Air National Guard that we honor for their receipt of the Distinguished Flying Cross are Lieutenant Colonel Willis Parker, Major Cody Gaby, Major Lance Welch, Major Stacy Sells, Captain Joshua Johnson, Captain James Spearman, First Lieutenant Andrew Weber, Technical Sergeant Joshua Osborne, Technical Sergeant Gage Seymour, Technical Sergeant Hunter Ricks, and Senior Airman Jonah Parham; and

WHEREAS, the receipt of the Distinguished Flying Cross by these heroic Airmen is the result of their actions taken as part of Operation INHERENT RESOLVE, where they were tasked to perform a combat air refueling mission and found themselves in the direct line of fire after two regional adversaries launched a coordinated offensive attack on Israel; and

WHEREAS, despite the high-stakes situations, the aircrew maintained their composure and relayed vital, real-time information updates, enabling other coalition forces to respond effectively to the attack. While evading airborne threats without the benefit of onboard defensive systems or situational awareness-enhancing tools common to combat aircraft, the aircrew adapted to their mission to meet the air refueling needs of numerous combat assets, enabling and enhancing the defense of the unprecedented attack with increased on-station time and engagement potential; and

WHEREAS, their exceptional aviation skills allowed the crews to offload tens of thousands of pounds of fuel during the mission, directly contributing to the successful defense of allied personnel and assets. The successful defense of the United States ally led directly to regional de-escalation over the next several days, saving countless lives. The professional competence, aerial skill, and devotion to duty displayed reflect great credit upon themselves, the Tennessee Air National Guard, and the United States Air Force; and

WHEREAS, these members of the 134th Air Refueling Wing of the Tennessee Air National Guard performed their duties with the utmost skill, dedication, and professionalism; their service can only be categorized as outstanding; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we hereby honor and commend the members of the 134th Air Refueling Wing of the Tennessee Air National Guard on their receipt of the Distinguished Flying Cross and offer our thanks for a difficult job well done.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to

the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.